Example 2: Observing a Place - Lectures at Universities

1 Stepping through the lecture theatre's door, the chill in the air is a familiar harbinger of battle. The room hums with a subdued buzz, carrying a subtle blend of expectation and uncertainty. The professor begins, and we are met with an unexpected twist—a minor glitch in the microphone prompts him to abandon it altogether, casually shrugging off the technical hiccup. The ripple effect this has is instantaneous, and students scramble for front-row seats, shuffling anxiously forward to secure the best spots for improved audibility.

2 The harsh tip-taps of keyboards create a steady stream of white noise, persisting even when the lecturer deviates from the novel. Students simply refuse to miss a word. This 'Fear of Losing Out' (FoLO) is a palpable tension that emerges as a motif in my interviews. One student confesses, "People are always vigilant of what is going on. If [I] suddenly hear people typing away, I feel obliged to take notes, because it might be something important." This obligation is intriguing. FoLO, understood thus, is a subtle cue-reading of an unspoken collective assessment of significance, which feeds back into the individual student's notes.

3 The announcement of a short recess pops open the bottle of tension—animated conversations immediately take the place of typing. The jumbled overlapping snippets of conversation, when put together, reveal self-depreciatory admissions of not being able to keep up in class, exposing the intellectual act from before to be but a facade.

4 Any brief respite abruptly ends with the start of small-group discussions in the second half of the lecture. Students fiercely stake their claims on interpretations, eager for recognition from their peers. If their strongly worded responses and rising volume might indicate that students have developed their own ideas, the profound silence meeting the professor's invitation to have an open discussion refutes that. In the midst of this quiet uncertainty, only a few courageous souls speak up.

5 Despite some strong interpretations, students rarely note down responses from their peers, only jotting down what the professor picks up. The validity of the idea then, is determined by whose idea it is, rather than the idea itself. This fidgeting, frantic note-taking and collective responses viewed in totality insidiously highlight a pervasive sense of comparison and self-doubt, revolving around students' compulsion to showcase their competence in lectures. What do these observed tensions unveil of students' broader experiences within the education system?